

While classical Stoicism doesn't have an official, numbered "commandments" list like some traditions, modern teachers and translators usually distill the vast writings of Marcus Aurelius, Epictetus, and Seneca into ten foundational, practical principles.

At its core, Stoicism isn't about suppressing emotion; it's an active, daily practice designed to cultivate psychological resilience, clear judgment, and an unwavering inner calm.

1. The Dichotomy of Control

This is the absolute bedrock of Stoic practice, famously articulated by Epictetus. You must constantly separate life into two distinct buckets: what is up to you, and what is not.

- **Up to you:** Your opinions, values, intentions, and reactions.
- **Not up to you:** The weather, the past, the future, global events, and the behavior or opinions of other people.

"Some things are in our control and others not. Things in our control are opinion, pursuit, desire, aversion, and, in a word, whatever are our own actions. Things not in control are body, property, reputation, command, and, in one word, whatever are not our own actions." — Epictetus

2. Mastery over Perception

Events themselves do not cause us suffering; it is the *judgment* we place on those events that causes distress. When a difficult situation arises, a Stoic pauses before reacting, recognizing that they have the power to choose how they interpret the event.

3. The Four Cardinal Virtues

Stoics believe that living a good life means living in alignment with "Virtue" (*Arete*), which they view as the sole true good. This overarching virtue is broken down into four practical character traits that serve as an internal compass:

- **Wisdom (*Phronesis*):** Knowing what is good, what is bad, and what is indifferent. It is practical navigation of complex situations.
- **Courage (*Andreia*):** Facing daily challenges, standing up for what is right, and enduring hardship without losing your integrity.
- **Justice (*Dikaiosyne*):** Your duty to the human community. Acting with fairness, kindness, and public spirit.
- **Temperance/Moderation (*Sophrosyne*):** Practicing self-restraint, self-control, and discipline over impulses.

4. Amor Fati (Love of Fate)

Coined as a formal phrase later but deeply rooted in ancient Stoicism, this is the practice of not just tolerating the things you cannot change, but actively accepting and embracing them. When something unexpected or challenging happens, you treat it as fuel for growth, learning, and character development.

5. Memento Mori (Remember You Will Die)

To the Stoics, meditating on our mortality isn't morbid—it's incredibly grounding. Remembering that life is brief and fleeting strips away trivial anxieties, humbles the ego, and anchors you deeply into the value of the present moment.

6. Premeditatio Malorum (Negative Visualization)

This is the practice of intentionally imagining potential setbacks, disruptions, or losses before they occur. By mentally preparing for worst-case scenarios, you remove the element of shock if they do happen, reduce catastrophic thinking, and naturally increase your gratitude for what you currently have.

7. Voluntary Discomfort

Seneca advised taking a few days every month to eat the cheapest food, wear rough clothes, and step away from comfort. By voluntarily exposing yourself to minor hardships, you break the psychological dependency on luxury and realize that the things you fear losing actually have very little hold over your inner well-being.

8. The View from Above

When trapped in stress or personal drama, Stoics practice mentally zooming out. Imagine looking at your neighborhood, your city, the earth, and eventually the vastness of cosmic time and space. This cognitive reframing puts personal anxieties into a healthy perspective, reminding us of our shared place in the broader human fabric.

9. Sympatheia (Mutual Interdependence)

Stoics do not view themselves as isolated individuals, but as cells in a larger organism—the human community. *Sympatheia* is the recognition that we are all deeply interconnected. What harms the beehive harms the bee; therefore, working for the common good is a fundamental requirement of human nature.

10. The Present Moment is the Only Reality

The past is unchangeable ink; the future is completely uncertain. The only arena where you can think, act, choose virtue, or practice awareness is right now. Stoicism emphasizes anchoring your attention firmly in the immediate task or breath at hand, refusing to let the mind drift into anxious anticipation or regret.

Core Philosophers at a Glance

If you are looking to dive deeper into the original source materials, these three thinkers offer distinct, complementary windows into how these principles look in practice:

Philosopher	Background	Primary Work	Voice & Focus
Seneca	Wealthy playwright, advisor to Nero	<i>Letters from a Stoic</i>	Pragmatic, highly literary, focused on

Philosopher	Background	Primary Work	Voice & Focus
			friendship, aging, and daily balance.
Epictetus	Born a slave, later founded a famous philosophy school	<i>Discourses & Enchiridion</i>	Direct, sharp, and uncompromising on personal freedom and personal responsibility.
Marcus Aurelius	Roman Emperor	<i>Meditations</i>	Introspective, deeply private journal entries on duty, leadership, and humility.